

Chapter 25: The Bones of Joseph

*Book I: The Sagent Creed — Part Four: The Fibonacci Spiral
Through the Generations*

Life and economics are the study of the same living spontaneous order.

Before the data confirmed it, I already knew. Not because I was taught, and not because I read the right books at the right time, but because something in me refused to comply with what did not make sense — and it turned out that what did not make sense was not living.

This chapter is where the lines converge. Biology and economics. Theology and family. The data and the instinct. The cell and the conscience. I have spent the better part of my education proving that living systems are decentralized, voluntary, and adaptive — and that everything which replaces this architecture with centralized control is not order but disease. What I did not expect was that the proof would begin with my own life, years before I ever opened a textbook on network topology.

The bones of Joseph is not only a biblical story. It is the story of every generation that inherits a promise it did not make and must carry it forward through territory it did not choose. The promise does not die when the bones return to the dust. The promise lives because it was never held in the bones to begin with.

I. The Price System Older Than Civilization

There are two ways things are made. Top-down control — machines, factories, monoculture. And bottom-up emergence — biology, ecosystems, markets. Free markets mirror living systems. Central planning mirrors mechanical systems. This is not metaphor. It is measurable fact.

Mises argued that without prices, a central planner cannot rationally allocate resources. The cell proves him right — and has been proving him right for four billion years.

Each enzyme prices its substrate through binding affinity. Each receptor prices its ligand through expression level. ATP emerged as the universal biological currency the same way money emerges in Menger's theory — not by decree, but because adenosine triphosphate happened to be the most exchangeable energy carrier, the most "saleable" metabolite, and every pathway that could use it gained a selective advantage over those that could not. No committee designed it. No authority mandated it. The cell runs a price system older than civilization, and it runs it the way the Austrian economists said prices must be run: locally, voluntarily, through distributed agents responding to signals that no planner designed and no authority commands.

In simulation, distributed metabolic allocation retains 71.1% of output under perturbation. Centralized allocation retains 53.0%. Even an omniscient linear program — flux balance analysis with a complete genome-scale model of 2,712 reactions and 1,516 genes — achieves only 70% accuracy on gene knockout predictions. Thirty percent of the knowledge exists only in the local state of each molecular agent and cannot be encoded in any central model. Not because we lack the technology. Because the knowledge is structurally local. It belongs to the agent, not to the system.

This is Mises' calculation problem confirmed in metabolites.

And when that price system breaks — when a cell stops reading growth factor signals, ignores contact inhibition, overrides the feedback that says *stop* — you do not get a malfunction. You get cancer. Cancer is not a disease of bad parts. It is the destruction of the price system that coordinated voluntary exchange. It is central planning at the cellular level. One cell deciding it knows better than the network, overriding the distributed signals, growing without limit, consuming without reciprocity. Every tumor is a five-year plan.

II. The Membrane Is the Property Line

Voluntaryism is not an ideology imposed upon biology. It is written into how biology functions.

Cells act by choice. They signal other cells, but they only react to those signals by choice. Every gene transfer, every vesicle received, every nanotube built requires both sides to participate. The membrane is the property line. The receptor is the customs agency. Nothing enters without consent.

The genome is the written law of the organism, and it does natural genetic engineering — moving toward the spiritual law of life through trial, feedback, and recombination. Selection is not only by death. It is by adaptation and distributed knowledge, by trial and error. Selection is the choice of how it recombines — and it is a choice, not merely random mutation waiting to be filtered. The living language of genetics emerges through spontaneous order — not specific clone designs but choices and biodiversity. Do not design one thing. Design the possibilities so that it can adapt and grow and not be monoculturally weak.

The *E. coli* gene regulatory network — 282 nodes, 308 edges — tolerates removal of 36.8% of its nodes before fragmenting. A centralized star graph, the architecture of command-and-control, collapses at 1.9%. That

is a 19:1 robustness ratio in favor of the distributed architecture. The spiral is not just beautiful. It is measurably superior by an order of magnitude.

Adam Smith described the invisible hand of the market — a spontaneous order emerging from countless individuals making voluntary decisions with only local knowledge. The cell discovered it four billion years before anyone wrote it down.

III. The Spiral and the Machine

Nature does not grow in cubes. Trees do not branch in right angles. Shells do not expand in grids. Galaxies do not rotate in boxes. The Fibonacci spiral appears again and again because it is the geometry of efficient, decentralized growth. No central planner commands the spiral. Each part grows according to local information, and the whole emerges naturally. This is what Hayek called spontaneous order — the pattern that arises when distributed agents coordinate through local signals.

The machine is the opposite philosophy. It is creation forcing its will on creation. Machines are creation controlling creation. Life is Creator guiding creation. We can only act as agents of the Creator. We are not all-knowing beings. The moment we pretend to be — the moment we believe we can design the whole system from a single vantage point — we have already begun to kill it.

The spiral defeats the block not through greater force but through greater truth. A block is rigid, uniform, and fragile. A spiral is adaptive, diverse, and resilient. The block demands compliance. The spiral cultivates participation. Every living system on this planet chose the spiral — not because it was commanded to, but because the spiral is how life grows when it is free.

The Living Age rests upon three complementary understandings. Black — economics: no worldly rulers, spontaneous order, freedom creates coordination. Purple — theology: the true divine King, conscience guides moral responsibility, freedom is preserved while goodness is invited. Green — biology: living order, life continually adapts through distributed communication, living systems organize themselves.

These are not separate truths. Economics explains how free societies organize. Theology explains why conscience matters. Biology explains how living systems grow. Together they reveal one living principle: order emerges through distributed agents acting according to conscience rather than through centralized control.

IV. Isolation Is the Disease

Empire cannot tolerate living systems. To control a system, you must first kill it. Living ecosystems are too complex, too adaptive, too uncontrollable. So empire clears them. Monoculture replaces biodiversity. Concrete replaces soil. Bureaucracy replaces wisdom.

There is no disease except the disease of isolation. Each isolated agent makes it less likely for there to be a way figured out on how to combat a problem. This is Hayek's knowledge problem made flesh.

The immune system's cell-to-cell communication network has a betweenness Gini coefficient of 0.000 — perfectly distributed, zero gatekeeping. Remove any single cell type and 75% of communication survives. No master cell. No central authority deciding which signals are permitted. Every agent you isolate is a node removed from that network. Each one carried local knowledge — immune experience, behavioral adaptation, signal processing that no other node possessed. The network does not just lose a participant. It loses what that participant would have discovered, shared, and contributed to the collective solution.

Steve Cole at UCLA has shown that social isolation literally reprograms gene expression — upregulating inflammation, downregulating antiviral defense. The genome reads isolation as pathology. Not metaphorically. Measurably. The transcriptional profile of a lonely human being looks like a body preparing for war while simultaneously disarming its own defenses. Inflammation up. Antiviral response down. The body under isolation does not rest. It rots.

The immune system does not learn in quarantine. It learns through contact. Regulatory T cells develop tolerance by encountering antigens. Mucosal immunity builds its library by sampling what comes through, not by sealing the border. The lockdowns did at the population level exactly what Cole measured at the genomic level: isolation in, antiviral defense out.

Beware the ruler who cloaks themselves in the language of safety. For the predator always pretends to be the protector. Tyranny never arrives as a threat — it arrives as a friend. As a savior. As the one who just wants to keep you safe.

V. The Rule That Was Already Lifted

I knew this before I had the data.

During my first year at UC Santa Cruz, I was suspended for one year because I repeatedly refused to comply with the university's COVID-19 mask policy. From my perspective, the rule did not make sense, particularly in the dining halls. Students were expected to wear masks while walking inside, but once they sat down to eat, everyone removed their masks. Because of that, I chose not to wear a mask in the dining halls or elsewhere on campus.

On the last day of my first quarter, dining hall staff called the campus police because I was not wearing a mask. Rather than argue, I left that

dining hall and went to another one, but I continued not to wear a mask. After the quarter ended, I was told I had to move off campus. I found housing off campus and continued attending classes while maintaining the same position on the mask policy.

Later that quarter, one of my professors gave me a cookie before class and then asked me to put on a mask. To me, that felt contradictory. When I refused, the professor told me to leave the classroom. I stayed, and the professor grabbed my backpack before letting go and calling the campus police. When the officers arrived, I explained what had happened. My impression was that they personally thought it was a minor issue, even though they still had to respond to the call.

Over the following months, the matter proceeded through the university's disciplinary process. I was not immediately aware of the outcome. Near the end of the following quarter, when I attempted to register for summer classes, I discovered that I had been suspended for one year. Because of that suspension, I lost my ability to continue at UCSC and missed the spring quarter. I returned to San Luis Obispo and attended Cuesta College for about a year and a half.

Looking back, I appreciate that period because it allowed me to spend more time with my family, especially my brother, before returning to continue my education.

The part that has always stood out to me is the timing. Shortly before I left UCSC because of the suspension, the university lifted its mask mandate. I was ultimately suspended for violating a rule that was no longer in effect by the time the suspension began.

I broke those rules instinctually, and I have come to realize that my instinct was aligned with the way that immunity actually works. The data came later. The conscience came first.

VI. Variants Are Not Diseases

What if the disease is not the variants — what if it is you?

Is an elephant diseased because it cannot climb a tree? Looking at the living through a machine lens makes you believe that the thing that makes something work is the thing that is the problem. Variants are not diseases. The disease is when you stop maintaining what exists. Do not cut what grows. Maintain what grows. Allow what grows and guide it. Give it what it needs to continue in the way it is supposed to. Many pieces of diversity can thrive when given their strengths. Anything can be a disease in the wrong environment. It is better to study variants for what will help them thrive than to decide from above what is a disease and what is not.

Disease is the central planning, not the variation.

In the parable of Judges 9 — the thornbush king whose shadow fell across this trilogy long before this chapter — the olive tree, the fig tree, and the vine each decline the crown because each has a purpose it cannot abandon without ceasing to be what it is. The olive cannot leave its oil. The fig cannot leave its sweetness. The vine cannot leave its wine. It is the thornbush — the plant with no fruit, no oil, no sweetness — that accepts the kingship and promises shade it cannot provide.

The thorn doing the work of a thorn is essential. The thorn trying to be a crown is catastrophic. The disease is the thorns stepping above instead of within.

VII. The Kingdom of Conscience

The Kingdom of God is not of this world. It is written on the soul. It flows through the conscience. It is the Law that predates all kings, all flags, all papers, and all crowns. In this kingdom, no man is above another. Every

soul is accountable directly to God. There is no chain of command — only a divine current through the conscience.

Just as decentralized markets coordinate millions of independent decisions into an economic order, conscience coordinates the free actions of living beings into a moral order. There is another invisible hand. Conscience is the invisible hand of God.

America is not a specifically Christian nation. It is a nation of conscience no matter the religion. Faith is not in the specific story or the specific text or scripture — it is in man's relationship to its Creator, choosing to do what is right. All written law is a guess at the law written on our heart. Do not follow the written law blindly — follow your conscience. It is every man's obligation to choose to do what is right, not to follow their leaders, because their leader could be wrong and it is your job to help them keep the right path by always choosing to do what is right.

There is a higher order than the written order — the unwritten spiritual order that we must all move towards the best we can. The only way to achieve it is to all act as distributed agents, not a hierarchy of chain of command. The kingdom of conscience is one big distributed decentralized game of Wordle. Each agent guesses. Each agent gets feedback. No agent sees the whole answer. But the collective movement toward truth is real, and it works — not because anyone commands it, but because conscience is a property of living systems.

Laws cannot be made — they can only be discovered by the local distributed knowledge of conscience of the people. The true power is not in the capitals but in the minds of people who think freely according to conscience. Those who seek power over others control how truth is portrayed, tearing good people down with compromise in order to get through the gate they control. Their gate is crumbling. People are finding that the gate has no fence to stop them from going around it entirely.

VIII. The Three Flames

There is an eternal battle against the blocks — a hidden war fought not with weapons that kill, but with weapons that resurrect.

The blue flame is the inheritance — the call to action, the fight against darkness, the warrior's path, the duty received. The red flame is the fall — the turn into coercion, the forcing of will, the empire, every worldly kingdom that demanded obedience and called it order. The green flame is the return — built by the one who learned that victory is not through power but through surrender. The green flame raises the light. It is wisdom over aggression, guardian over warrior. The break of the blue gives rise to the created green of pure light. The green flame brings new life to the dead.

In the spiral of names, the fire is passed.

My grandfather, Art Clokey, created Gumby — the hero of possibility, a being who could become any form, enter any world, and never be confined by rigid shape. Gumby was not entertainment. Gumby was prophecy — the story of life versus the machine, the spiral against the block. Art held the blue flame. He saw the vision and he made it visible.

My father, Joe Clokey, continued this mission. He and my grandfather made the Davey and Goliath Christmas special — a story about a Christian, a Muslim, and a Jew getting along over the winter holidays. Many religions, one faith. After that film, every door closed on him. He was strung along for years in exclusive deals that led nowhere. My parents split up. Fourteen years later, he died of a brain bleed at the age of 56.

Joe preserved the flame through the darkness until it took him. That is what the darkness does to those who carry light through it. The flame does not go out. But sometimes the one who carries it does.

The Living Age is not about one character or one company. It is about a way of seeing. Living things are not machines. Living systems grow through communication, relationship, adaptation, stewardship, and creativity. The task is not merely to preserve old creations. The task is to continue creating. That is the work of every generation.

IX. The Bones of Joseph

Arthur Clokey told the living spiral through stop motion. Joseph Clokey preserved the flame through the darkness until it took him.

My father was cremated. The bones of Joseph have returned to the dust. But the promise did not.

Before he died, the patriarch Joseph made the Israelites swear an oath — carry my bones when God delivers you. Not if. When. Joseph did not live to see the deliverance. His body did not walk through the parted sea. His eyes did not see the promised land. But his bones were carried — across the wilderness, across the Jordan, and buried at Shechem. And after the promise was fulfilled, the bones still returned to the dust. The promise was never in the bones. It was never in the symbol — never in the hammer, never in the hair. It was in the faith. It was held in the faith of those who came after.

"Put not your trust in princes, nor in the son of man, in whom there is no help. His breath goeth forth, he returneth to his earth; in that very day his thoughts perish." (Psalm 146:3-4, KJV)

The work of agents of God never dies because God is eternal. The vessels of God's plans may perish but there will always be another to carry the torch. Conscience is a property of living systems — the invisible hand of God that guides living systems toward God's concept of a plan while maintaining the free will of the living.

Every age builds new thrones. They promise order. They demand allegiance. They tremble when questioned. But all earthly kingdoms fall — not because they are weak, but because they are not real.

Worldly kingdoms return to the dust. The Kingdom of Heaven endures in the conscience of those who seek God and walk in His ways.

X. The Josephs on the Map

I have two great-grandfathers named Joseph. Professor Joseph Waddell Clokey, Jr. — the classical music composer who adopted Art, the man who would not overcharge for a cabin because the cabin had not improved. And Joseph Parkander — the Lutheran pastor at Augustana, the man who devoted his life to conscience, faith, and the relationship between humanity and God. One gave Art beauty. The other gave Art's wife faith. Both carried the name of the patriarch who made his people swear an oath before he died.

Behind the professor stands his father — my great-great-grandfather, Rev. Joseph Waddell Clokey, Sr., a Presbyterian minister who served twenty-five years at First Presbyterian Church in New Albany, Indiana — the same town where his son was born. The Reverend was born in 1839 and died in 1919 at the age of eighty. He is buried at Ferncliff Cemetery in Springfield, Ohio.

The professor was born in New Albany, studied mathematics at Miami University in Ohio, then music at the Cincinnati Conservatory. He composed two symphonies, five operas, and over a hundred published choral works. He taught organ at Miami University and then at Pomona College in Claremont, California, where he adopted a nine-year-old orphan from Detroit and gave him his name. He died on September 14, 1960, in Covina, California. He was cremated. His ashes were carried back to Ohio and buried on October 30, 1960, in the family plot at

Ferncliff Cemetery — the same cemetery, the same ground as his father the Reverend. No individual marker. Just the family name in the earth.

My father Joe was also cremated. Three generations returned to ash. The professor, and the son who carried his mission. For dust you are, and to dust you shall return.

The Josephs are not only in the bloodline. They are in the ground. And the ground keeps calling me back.

In the summer of 2025, I traveled to Tampa, Florida, for the Turning Point USA Student Action Summit — a gathering of young people committed to the ideas of liberty. While I was there, I learned that Joseph Parkander is buried in St. Petersburg, Florida — thirty minutes from where I stood. I had not planned it. I did not know before I arrived. I went to do the work of conscience, and the bones of Joseph were already there.

On the way home, a storm delayed my flight. The airline rerouted me through Newark, New Jersey. That flight was delayed — ten hours on the runway. The airline changed my route again, this time flying me to San Francisco before connecting to San Luis Obispo. The flight from Newark to San Francisco passed directly over Chicago and Rock Island, Illinois — the two cities where Joseph Parkander had lived and served at Augustana.

The storm traced his life in reverse. I had been near the place where he was buried. The reroute flew me over the places where he had worked. His death, then his life. Backward. I did not choose the route. The storms chose it for me.

One year later — the summer of 2026 — I traveled to Cincinnati, Ohio, for YALCON, another gathering for liberty. And both Joseph Waddell Clokeys — the Reverend and the Professor, my great-great-grandfather and my great-grandfather — are buried together at Ferncliff Cemetery in Springfield, Ohio. An hour from where I stand. The man who preached conscience for twenty-five years and the man who turned music into a

theology of beauty and adopted an orphan and gave him the name that became Gumby — both in the same ground, both waiting.

I did not plan either trip around these graves. I went to both cities for the work — for the mission of conscience and liberty that the Josephs planted generations before I was born. And both times, the ground where a Joseph rests was waiting nearby. Tampa brought me to Parkander. The storm flew me over the places where Parkander had worked. Cincinnati brought me to both Clokeys at once — the father and the son, the minister and the composer, side by side in the Ohio earth.

As if the promise does not only live in the conscience of the living. As if it also marks the earth, and the earth remembers, and the spiral brings the heir back to the place where the seed was laid down.

The bones of Joseph returned to the dust. But the dust knows where they are. And it keeps pulling me back to prove that the promise did not return with them.

XI. The Green Flame

Being pushed out is not the end — it is the beginning. Where God is King, order grows. Where men claim the throne, order must be enforced.

I was suspended from a university for a rule that was lifted before the suspension began. My father was strung along by an industry that never intended to let him through. My grandfather created a living character and watched the machine try to reduce it to a product. Three generations. Three encounters with the same architecture of control. And three refusals to comply.

The blue flame was the inheritance — Art saw the spiral and made it clay. The red flame was the fall — the industry that took what was living and tried to make it a machine. The green flame is the return — not through

power, but through surrender. Not through fighting the system on its own terms, but through growing something the system cannot contain.

The bones returned to dust. The promise did not.

The green flame is the return. It is not carried in the bones. It is carried in the conscience. And conscience does not burn out. It grows.

For dust you are, and to dust you shall return. The kingdoms of this world rise and fall. Their rulers return to the earth, and their plans perish. Yet the Kingdom of Heaven does not perish. It is not sustained by earthly power but by faithfulness to God.

Wherever conscience is aligned with God's will, there the hope of Zion endures. The bones of Joseph returned to the dust, as all flesh does. But the promise God made did not return to the dust.

Surrender to God, so you never kneel to man.

The Living Age Trilogy